

## WHAT DOES IT TAKE TO QUIT SHOPPING? MUTE, DELETE AND UNSUBSCRIBE.

Marketers followed consumers to social media and their phones. “Low Buy 2025” influencers are sharing tips for how to resist them.



### The New York Times

Feb. 28, 2025

By Jordyn Holman and Aimee Ortiz

Cassandra Orakpo had enough. Too much, in fact. Shopping on her phone had become so easy it had turned into a bad habit. [...] Ms. Orakpo joined a growing group of shoppers who are fed up with a constant **barrage** of marketing in their social feeds and phone alerts. Many have taken to TikTok — the site of much of their frustration — to declare that they are participating in “Low Buy 2025” or “No Buy 2025” and sharing the ways they are curbing their spending. 5 Some “shop their closet,” and others pledge to **make sure their containers of blush hit pan** before being **enticed** into buying a new one. The videos have garnered millions of views since the start of the year.

The zeal that is driving this trend is as much a pushback against the forces of a consumerist culture as it is about saving money, with scorn for corporate manipulation mixed in with tips for changing personal habits. On the scorn end of the spectrum is a call for an “economic blackout” on Friday by the People’s Union USA, which says it is fighting “an 10 economy designed to exploit workers, suppress wages and keep the majority of us in a constant state of struggle.” The group is asking people not to buy from large corporations — in person or online — for 24 hours.

Avoiding sales pitches from big corporations, however, is harder than ever. As more Americans spend time on social media, brands have **flocked** there to capture attention and dollars. [...] On TikTok, ads for phone stands, wigs and kitchen sink strainers are nearly indistinguishable from content creators opining about reality-TV shows and politics. 15 TikTok Shop, where people can make purchases without leaving the platform, was the single largest driver of U.S. social commerce sales growth in 2024, said Jasmine Enberg, principal analyst at Emarketer. Nearly half of TikTok users are expected to make at least one purchase on the platform this year, she added.

People are also buying things on Instagram, Facebook Marketplace and YouTube. According to a Bankrate survey released in September 2023, Americans spent \$71 billion on impulse purchases on social media over the previous year 20 — purchases that often ended in feelings of regret. Ms. Orakpo is among the regretful. But now she’s determined to resist the **wiles** of advertisers who invade her phone on social media, email and text. “It’s a whole ecosystem, and it’s hard to avoid. But it is feeling predatory, it is feeling like manipulation,” Ms. Orakpo said. “It is getting heavy.”

### Addicted to Buying

For those trying to **curb** their shopping habits, social media can be a hazardous place.

25 “The more time you spend on social media, the more inclined you are to engage with your favorite brands but also buy impulsively, make unplanned purchases,” said Angeliki Nikolinakou, an associate professor at the University of Western Macedonia in Greece, who co-wrote a 2024 paper on the subject.

For some, social media can aggravate a recognized disorder sometimes called compulsive buying behavior, which, according to a 2015 meta-analysis of studies from 16 countries, affects roughly 5 percent of adults. Modern marketing 30 strategies — having influencers **hawk** products and **promote hauls**, and creating urgency through games or short promotion windows (One item left! Selling fast!) — can have a real effect on people with compulsive shopping, said Dr. Astrid Müller, an associate professor at Hannover Medical School in Germany who studies compulsive buying

behavior. “There may be constant social comparison or even competitive-like exchange in forums about ‘hunting’ for and purchasing particular goods or merchandise products,” Dr. Müller said.

- 35 Hannah Radke, a 33-year-old home health care worker in Nampa, Idaho, said her compulsive shopping habits worsened when she became a mother and started buying things for her daughter. She found herself scrolling Facebook Marketplace, looking for deals during **downtime** at work and late at night after her daughter went to bed. Her social media feed was a cornucopia of irresistible ads and holiday sales pitches. She’d be enticed to add items to her cart to meet a retailer’s minimum order value, buying more things — often frivolous — than she had meant to.
- 40 “My shopping addiction is about **the high** that I get when I buy something and have something new or I have a package coming in the mail or I get to open something,” Ms. Radke said. Having bought multiple sets of the same items, she has pajamas, blankets and toys in her home that have never been used. In 2022, she was sentenced to probation and community service after being caught **swapping** tags on items in a store. Afterward, she opened up about her shopping compulsion to her therapist. Ms. Radke now finds comfort at Shopping Addiction Support, a private Facebook group
- 45 with more than 14,000 members. [...]

### Relevant Marketing?

Some people might consider Amit Jhavar part of the problem. As the chief executive of Attentive, he sends brand messages by way of texts to your phone. But Mr. Jhavar says he is part of the solution. People are overwhelmed. He gets it. But companies have to get their messages out, and customers do want to know about sales and updates from

50 their favorite brands. He thinks marketing that is more personalized — and easier to opt out of — is better for everybody.

That’s where texting comes in. Companies like texts because people open them faster than emails and texts feel more personal and easier to engage with. And it’s easier to **opt out** of text messages than to unsubscribe from email, so brands have to be more careful about what they send consumers, for fear of alienating them, Mr. Jhavar said. Brands

55 often offer customers a discount in return for signing up for the Attentive messages. “We’re not sending you crappy messages that you have to go and sort through and delete and get all these notifications that aren’t relevant,” said Mr. Jhavar, who previously was chief executive at Venmo. [...]

### The Resistance

In online communities for shopping addictions and overspending, people trade tips and tricks on how to resist the

60 sophisticated marketing strategies of people like Mr. Jhavar.

Lea Toshiye Roache, a 34-year-old content creator in Dallas, **pledged** with a group of friends to spend less this year. Ms. Roache, who described herself as a “slight shopaholic,” has unfollowed brands on social media and unsubscribed to their emails and texts. She created rules that give her some **leeway**: “self-care” once a month or an “I just simply want it” purchase once a quarter. “**Spending bans are great**, and looking at your finances is great,” she said, “but also

65 make it realistic so that you can still be successful.”

Devon Rule is a founder and head of growth at Indyx, an app that helps people create a digital catalog of all the stuff in their closets. The service, which has a paid subscription option, started in 2022 and saw a large number of downloads on Jan. 1, which Ms. Rule took that as a sign of “No Buy” intentions.

“The business model is not selling you new stuff. It’s about helping you use what you have,” said Ms. Rule, who is

70 based in San Francisco and previously worked at fashion brands like Gap. “The idea is we’re competing with shopping.”

The financial incentive for the retail industry, or the “machine,” as she called it, is focused on persuading people to buy more items more frequently. And the internet and all of its tools allow shoppers to be “marketed to constantly, all the time,” she said.

“My take is it’s unrealistic to look to brands to moderate us on this,” Ms. Rule said. Instead, she said, consumers need

75 ask questions of themselves. Will they really wear that pair of black yoga pants that’s being advertised to them? Or will it just sit among the piles in an already **bulging** drawer? Ms. Orakpo, with the unused cake set, agrees. On TikTok, she has taken to quickly scrolling past influencers’ videos and any content from TikTok Shop. “I think it just comes down to me being **in the practice of scrolling past**,” she said.